Understanding Theme with Fables - Set 2

Name: _____ Date: _____

Directions: Read each fable. Determine its moral or theme, then explain which events support your interpretation. The moral is not stated in the story.

1. The Sparrow and the Storm

A young Sparrow built her nest on a branch that swayed above the meadow. Her neighbor, a Finch, warned her that strong winds often swept through the valley. The Sparrow laughed and said the sunny skies would last. Instead of strengthening her nest, she spent each afternoon singing. One evening, dark clouds gathered and a fierce wind shook the tree. The Finch sheltered safely in a nest woven tightly between sturdy branches, but the Sparrow watched hers fall apart. The next morning, she began rebuilding, carefully weaving each twig into place.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

_____

Explain how the story supports your answer:

_____

_____

2. The Fox and the Shining Pebble

A Fox found a sparkling pebble beside a stream. Thinking it must be precious, he tucked it beneath his paw and guarded it all day. When a hungry Rabbit offered to trade a basket of berries for it, the Fox refused. A Beaver later offered him a warm place to rest, but the Fox would not leave the pebble unguarded. By sunset, he was tired and hungry. Rain washed the mud from his treasure, revealing an ordinary stone. The Rabbit had already shared her berries with the Beaver, and both were resting comfortably.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

_____

Explain how the story supports your answer:

_____

_____

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3. The Tortoise and the Fallen Bridge

After heavy rain, a small bridge across the creek collapsed. A Tortoise needed to reach the other side before nightfall. He first tried to push a fallen log into place, but it was far too heavy. A Mouse suggested using several smaller branches. The Tortoise thought the idea was foolish and kept pushing the log alone. Hours passed without progress. At last, he listened to the Mouse. Together they laid branches across the narrowest part of the creek and crossed before sunset.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

_____

Explain how the story supports your answer:

_____

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4. The Owl and the Painted Feathers

A young Owl admired the bright feathers of the parrots. He covered his own brown feathers with colorful flower petals and flew into the forest hoping to impress everyone. At first, the birds gathered to stare. But when a lost chick called for help at dusk, the Owl worried that flying through the branches would ruin his decoration. A plain-looking older Owl quickly found the chick and guided it home. By morning, the petals had fallen from the young Owl's wings, but the birds still spoke warmly of the older Owl's kindness.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

_____

Explain how the story supports your answer:

_____

_____

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Directions: Read each fable. Determine its moral or theme, then explain which events support your interpretation. The moral is not stated in the story.

5. The Deer at the Crossing

A Deer came upon a river where the current was unusually fast. A Heron advised him to wait until the water slowed. The Deer, eager to be first to the meadow on the other side, stepped into the river anyway. The rushing water swept him toward a rocky bend. He barely managed to climb onto a small island. The Heron flew to fetch a Beaver, who showed him a safer crossing upstream. By the time the Deer reached the meadow, the other animals had arrived without danger.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

_____

Explain how the story supports your answer:

_____

_____

6. The Ant and the Lantern

An Ant discovered a lantern left beside a garden path. She wanted to carry it home so her colony could see after dark. She pulled the lantern with all her strength, but it barely moved. A Beetle offered to help, yet the Ant insisted she could do it herself. After several unsuccessful attempts, she finally accepted his offer. They called two more insects and moved the lantern together. That night, the Ant thanked them as the colony gathered in its warm glow.

What is the moral or theme of the story?

_____

Explain how the story supports your answer:

_____

_____

Answer Key - Sample Responses

Other reasonable themes and explanations supported by the text should also receive credit.

1. The Sparrow and the Storm

Possible theme: Prepare for difficulties before they arrive.

Supporting explanation: The sparrow ignored a warning and failed to strengthen her nest before the storm destroyed it.

2. The Fox and the Shining Pebble

Possible theme: Do not let greed or appearances blind you to what matters.

Supporting explanation: The fox rejected food and shelter to protect a pebble that turned out to be ordinary.

3. The Tortoise and the Fallen Bridge

Possible theme: Listening to others and working together can solve difficult problems.

Supporting explanation: The tortoise made no progress alone but succeeded after accepting the mouse's suggestion.

4. The Owl and the Painted Feathers

Possible theme: Character and helpful actions matter more than outward appearance.

Supporting explanation: The decorated owl attracted attention, while the older owl earned respect by helping the chick.

5. The Deer at the Crossing

Possible theme: Rushing ahead without considering danger can lead to trouble.

Supporting explanation: The deer ignored the warning, got stranded, and reached the meadow later by taking a safe route.

6. The Ant and the Lantern

Possible theme: Accepting help is a strength, not a weakness.

Supporting explanation: The ant could not move the lantern alone but succeeded when she welcomed others' help.